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Primatology

The Study of Primates

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What is a Primate?

- Primates are members of vertebrate class Mammalia
- 4000+ species of mammals
- Primates are a part of subgroup of placental mammals
- **Three types of primates**
  - Prosimians
  - Monkeys
  - Apes

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Common Mammalian Traits

1. Mammary glands
2. Fur (body hair in humans)
3. Long gestation and live birth (vivipary) relative to other types of organisms
4. Heterodontism (different kinds of specialized teeth)

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Common Mammalian Traits

7. Ability to maintain constant body temperature (Homeothermy)
8. Presence of external ear-pinna
9. Aneucleated and circular RBCs
10. Presence of placenta
11. Four chambered heart

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General Characteristics of Primates

- How many living species exist today is unclear and the number ranges between 230-270
- Most primates are arboreal, living in forest and woodland areas - Some old world primates do spend time on open land
- No primate, except human, is fully terrestrial – all spend some time in trees
- Most of the primates are diurnal – active during the day
- Most primates are restricted to tropical and subtropical areas of old & new worlds

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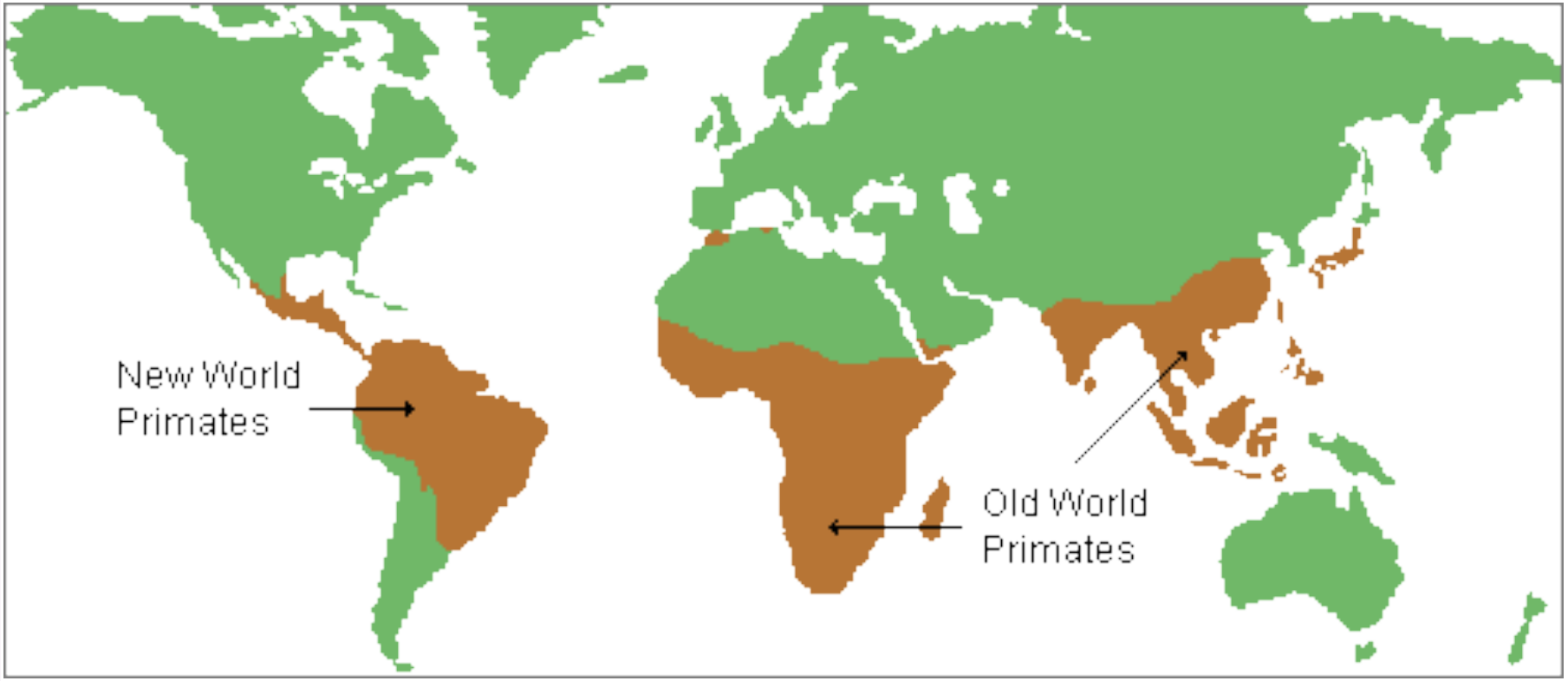
Geographical Distribution



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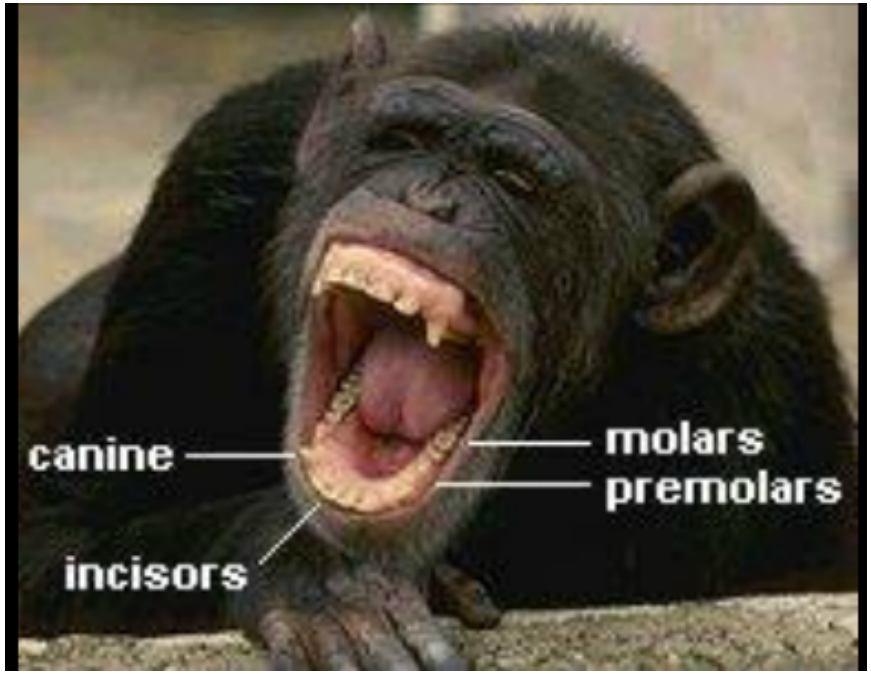
Dentition & Diet

- Omnivorous – generalized dentition makes this possible
- Although some prefer some food items over others, all eat a combination of fruits, leaves and insects
  - Some do eat meat – Chimps, baboons and humans
  - Some are leaf specialists – Colobine monkey
- Four types of teeth
  - Incisors & Canines – biting & cutting
  - Premolars & Molars – crushing & grinding



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General Characteristics of Primates

- Almost all of primates, except humans, are quadrupedal
- Many different types of locomotor adaptations
  - Vertical clinging
  - Brachiation
  - Quadrupedalism
  - Bipedalism
- All primates have marked tendency towards erectness in upper bodies – seen while sitting and standing

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Social Behavior

- Generally, primates are highly social animals - most of their waking hours are spent socializing with each other.
- Grooming is a very pleasurable activity for primates, including humans – cleaning and psychological satisfaction
- Primates are generally lively, clever, and very successful at adapting to different environmental opportunities.
- Almost all primates are gregarious except the nocturnal species

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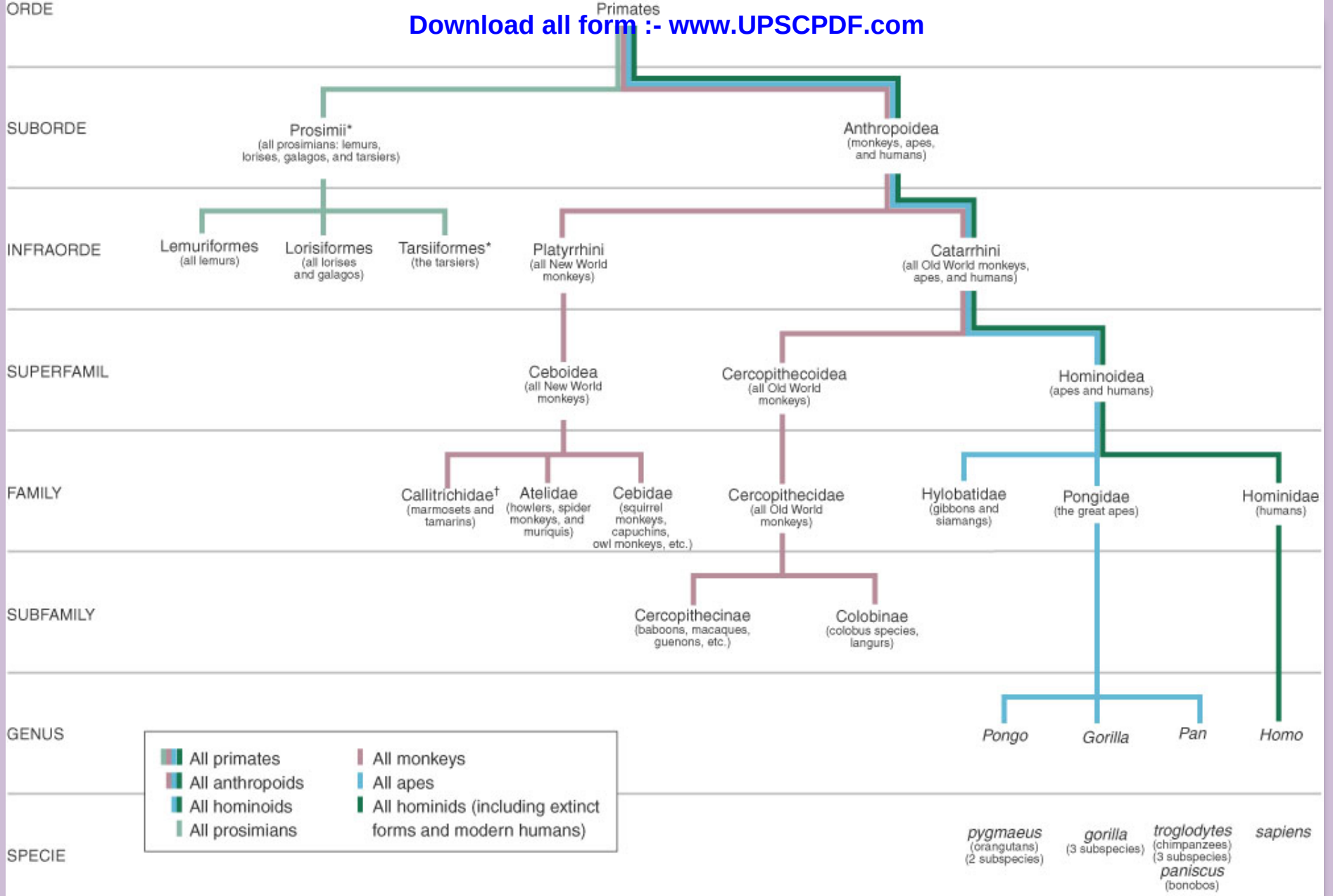

*There is some disagreement among primatologists concerning where to place tarsiers. Many researchers suggest that they more properly belong closer to the anthropoids and thus revise the primate classification to reflect this view. Here, for simplicity, we continue to use the traditional classifications.

†Fleagle (1999) and others have recently eliminated the family Callitrichidae and included marmosets and tamarins in the family Cebidae.

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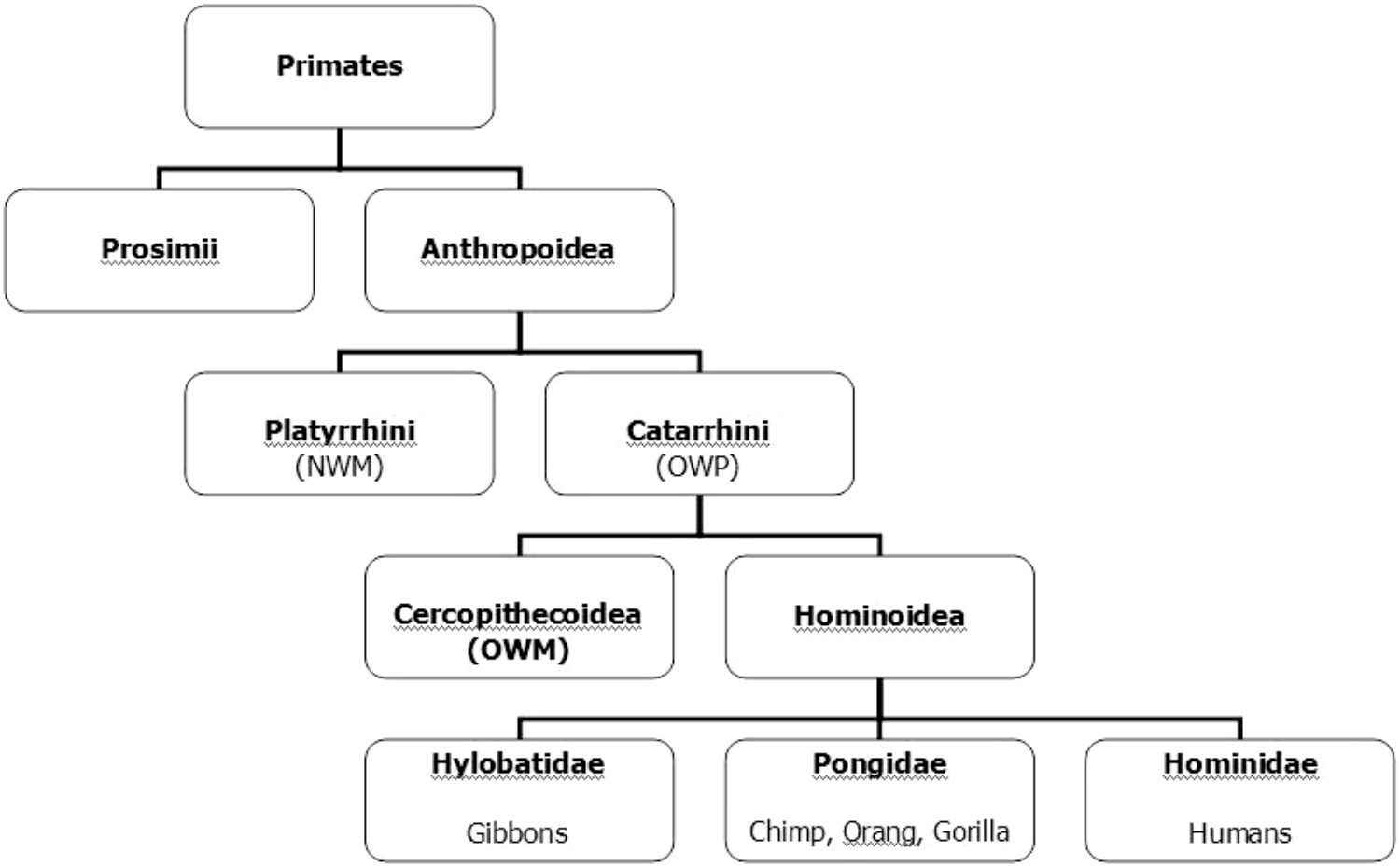
Classification of Primates



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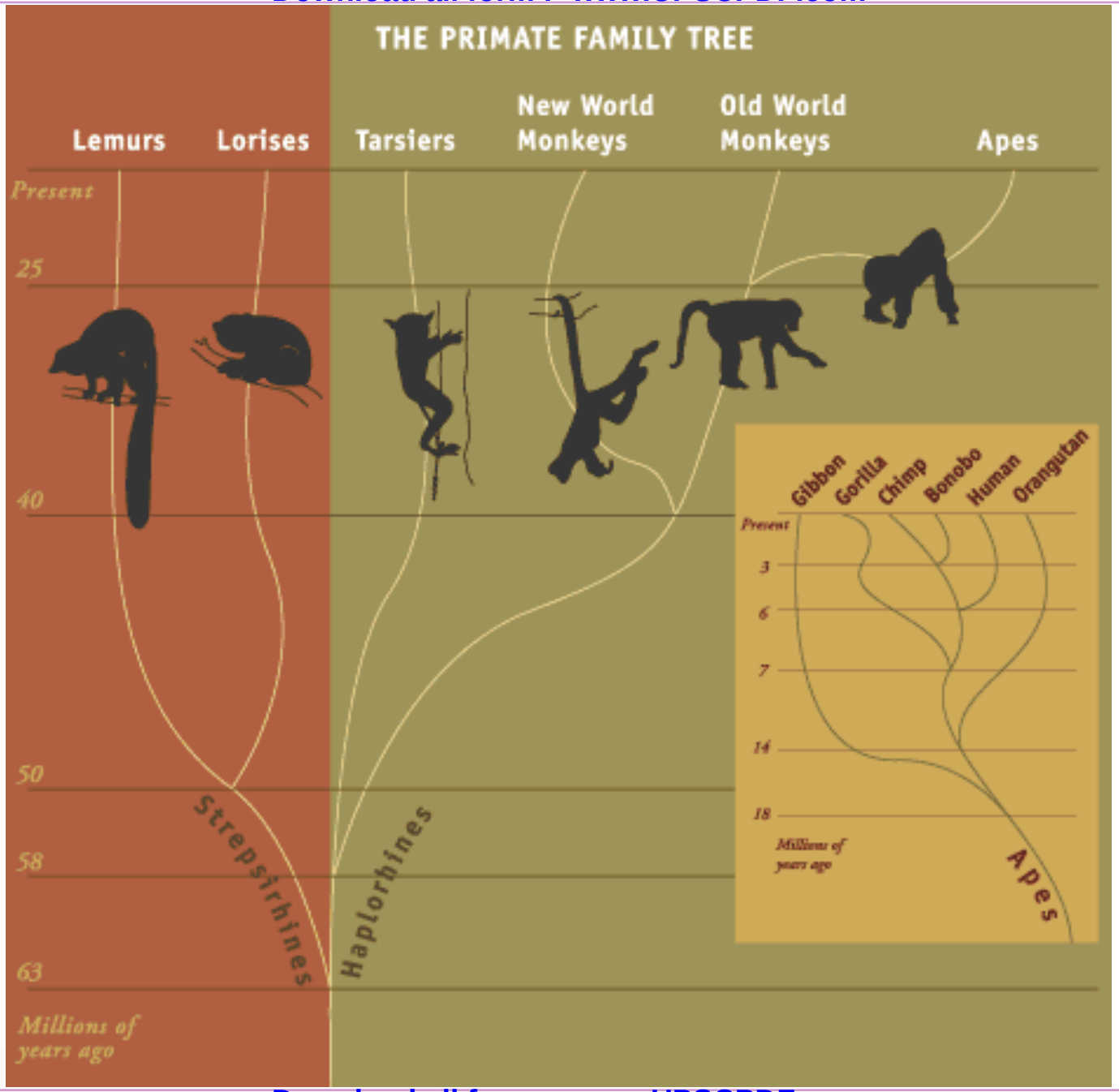

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Tarsier

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Lemur

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Saimiri sciureus

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Marmoset

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Capuchin

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Chlorocebus pygerythrus

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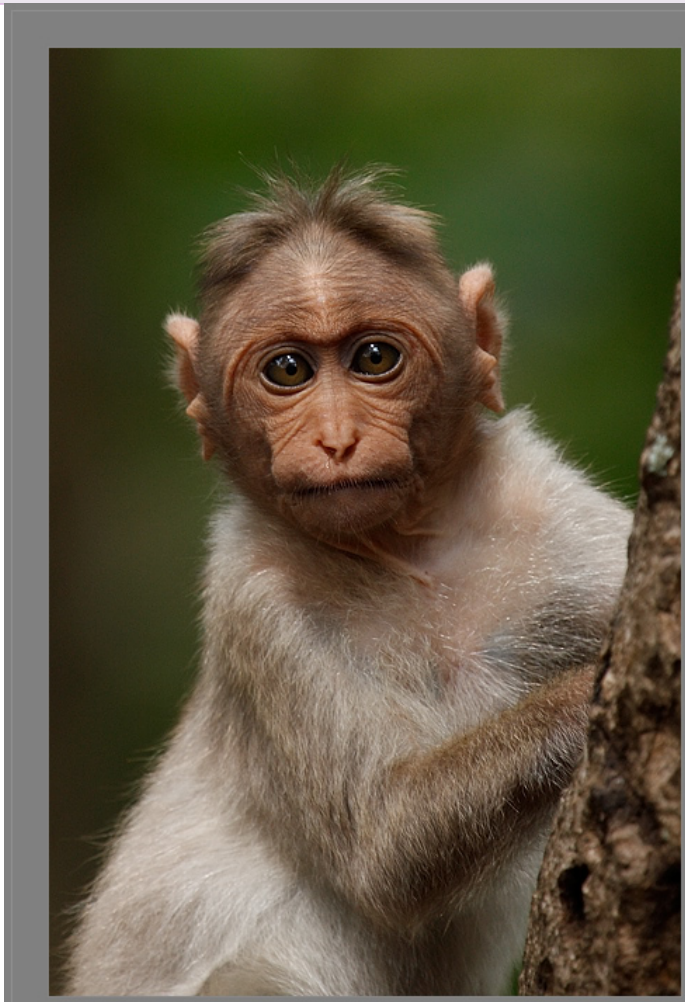
Macaca



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Gorilla

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Orang

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Chimp

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Orang & Man

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